

HUM44-2

GMAT Preparation

Test-taking strategy, timed practice, and admission positioning

The GMAT does not test what you know. It tests how you deliver what you know, under a clock.

Albert School — 12 hours

Preface

You have spent three semesters at Albert School learning to reason quantitatively, to read an argument critically, and to interpret data. This course assumes all of that and teaches none of it again. Its subject is narrower and, in a sense, more mercenary: how to convert the reasoning ability you already have into a **number between 200 and 800** that an admissions committee at HEC, ESSEC, LSE, Bocconi or ESADE will read in fifteen seconds and use to sort you.

That reframing matters, so let us be blunt about it from the start. The GMAT is not an education. It is a standardised instrument, and like any instrument it has a grain — patterns it rewards, traps it sets, a tempo it forces on you. A brilliant mathematician who has never seen Data Sufficiency will score worse on the Quantitative section than a competent one who has practised it for twenty hours, not because she is weaker but because she does not yet know what the section is actually asking. This course closes that gap.

We will therefore spend almost no time teaching mathematics, grammar, or logic from scratch — you have those. We will spend our time on three things the OP asks of us: knowing the **machine** (its sections, its scoring, what a target score even means), drilling the **strategy** for each section so that your existing ability survives contact with the clock, and then stepping back to the **admission strategy** that the score sits inside — because a 710 is wasted if you cannot frame it within a coherent Albert School dossier.

Remark (The test format evolves) Standardised tests are revised periodically, and the official provider can change section names, lengths, and scoring between editions. This book follows the four-section structure your programme specifies — Quantitative, Verbal, Integrated Reasoning, and Analytical Writing. Before you register, confirm the current official format and scoring on the test-maker’s website: the **strategy** in this book transfers across editions, but the **numbers** may have moved.

Contents

Preface	2
1 The machine: structure and scoring	4
1.1 A score is a sorting device, not a grade	4
1.2 The four sections	4
1.3 Scoring mechanics	4
1.4 What top MSc programmes expect, and setting a target	5
2 Quantitative section strategy	6
2.1 Two question types	6
2.2 The Data Sufficiency logic shift	6
2.3 Time management and trap avoidance	7
3 Verbal section strategy	8
3.1 Three question types	8
3.2 Reading comprehension: read for structure, not content	8
3.3 Critical reasoning: find the gap	9
3.4 Sentence correction: meaning and concision over “sounds right”	9
4 Integrated Reasoning strategy	9
4.1 Four formats	10
4.2 Strategy: practise the format, not the mathematics	10
5 Analytical Writing Assessment	10

5.1	What the task is — and is not	10
5.2	A reusable essay structure	11
5.3	Logical fallacies the GMAT tests	11
5.4	Planning under time pressure	11
6	Timed practice and error analysis	12
7	Weakness diagnosis and a personalised study plan	12
8	Admission strategy beyond the GMAT	13
8.1	School selection	13
8.2	How programmes weigh the dossier	13
8.3	Positioning the Albert School background	13
8.4	Timeline alignment	14

1 The machine: structure and scoring

1.1 A score is a sorting device, not a grade

Imagine two applicants to the same MSc in Management. Amir has a 3.9 GPA and a 640 GMAT. Béatrice has a 3.4 GPA and a 730 GMAT. On paper Amir is the stronger **student**; yet at many programmes Béatrice's file advances and Amir's stalls. Why? Because the committee does not read the GMAT as a measure of how much you learned. It reads it as a **common ruler**: the one number on the page that means the same thing whether you studied in Paris, Milan or São Paulo. The GPA is local — a 3.4 from a hard grader and a 3.9 from a lenient one are incomparable — but a 730 is a 730 everywhere.

Everything in this chapter follows from that single idea. You are not trying to **learn the GMAT**; you are trying to place yourself on a ruler, as high as your preparation time allows, so that the committee's fifteen-second glance lands in your favour.

1.2 The four sections

Definition 1 (The four GMAT sections) The exam this course prepares you for is built from four sections, each measuring a different competence under time pressure:

- **Quantitative** — problem-solving and Data Sufficiency, testing reasoning with numbers, not advanced mathematics.
- **Verbal** — reading comprehension, critical reasoning, and sentence correction, testing how you handle written argument and expression.
- **Integrated Reasoning** — multi-source reasoning, graphics interpretation, table analysis, and two-part analysis, testing synthesis across formats.
- **Analytical Writing Assessment (AWA)** — a single timed essay critiquing the reasoning of a given argument.

A crucial fact, easy to miss: these four sections do **not** all feed the same score. Understanding which feeds what is the difference between spending your preparation time wisely and squandering it.

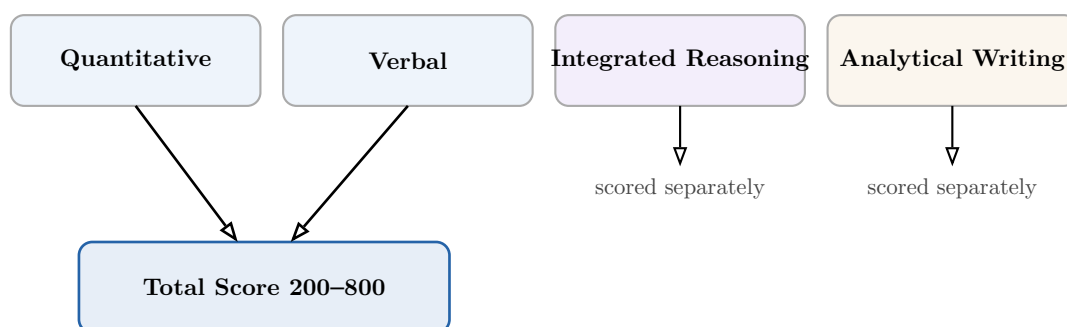


Figure 1: How the four sections roll up. Only Quantitative and Verbal combine into the headline Total Score (200–800), the number programmes quote in their ranges. Integrated Reasoning and the AWA are reported on their own separate scales and read as secondary signals.

1.3 Scoring mechanics

Definition 2 (The score scales)

- **Total Score** — runs from 200 to 800, in 10-point steps, computed from your Quantitative and Verbal performance together. This is the headline number.

- **Quantitative and Verbal** — each reported on its own section scale as well, so you can see which of the two is pulling your Total down.
- **Integrated Reasoning** — reported on a small separate integer scale (roughly 1–8).
- **Analytical Writing** — reported on a separate half-point scale (roughly 0–6), graded for the quality of the argument critique.

Common pitfall The single most common misreading of the GMAT by first-time test-takers is to treat all four sections as equally weighted toward “the score.” They are not. Programmes overwhelmingly quote and compare the **Total Score** (Quant + Verbal). Integrated Reasoning and AWA are real, but secondary: a strong essay will not rescue a weak Total, and a weak essay rarely sinks a strong one. Budget your scarce preparation hours accordingly — most of them belong to Quant and Verbal.

The test is also **adaptive**: it adjusts the difficulty of what it serves you in response to how you are doing, rather than handing everyone an identical fixed paper. Two consequences follow that change how you should play it. First, early questions disproportionately shape the difficulty band you settle into, so sloppy early errors are expensive. Second, on a truly adaptive section you generally cannot skip freely and return later the way you would on a paper exam; you must make a decision on each item as it comes. Both points reappear as concrete tactics in the Quantitative chapter.

1.4 What top MSc programmes expect, and setting a target

A target score is not “as high as possible.” It is the **lowest** score that takes the GMAT off the table as a reason to reject you — past that point, additional points buy rapidly diminishing returns, and the hours would be better spent on essays or internships. Setting it is a three-step calculation.

Worked example — Setting a realistic target. Clara wants the MSc in International Management at a programme whose admitted students cluster between 680 and 720 on the Total Score.

1. **Read the range.** She notes that competitive applicants sit at the **upper** half: she should aim for roughly 700–710, not the 680 floor.
2. **Take a diagnostic baseline.** Untrained and timed, she scores 620. The gap is about 80–90 points.
3. **Judge the gap against her hours.** An 80-point gain is realistic with disciplined preparation; a 200-point gain in a few weeks is not. She sets a target of 700 and a fallback of 680, and plans her study time around closing a Verbal weakness the diagnostic exposed.

The target-setting recipe. (1) Find the published or reported score range of each target programme and aim at its **upper** half. (2) Establish your own baseline from a **timed** diagnostic, not an untimed guess. (3) Set a target whose gap from the baseline is closable in the time you actually have — then spend your hours on the section the diagnostic says is weakest.

2 Quantitative section strategy

You arrive at this section over-qualified in mathematics and under-qualified in **GMAT mathematics**. The distinction is the whole chapter. The Quantitative section rarely needs anything beyond arithmetic, basic algebra, and elementary geometry — content you mastered years ago. What it tests is whether you can choose the **fast** path under a clock, resist baited wrong answers, and — in one question type — suppress the very instinct that has served you all your life: the instinct to compute the answer.

2.1 Two question types

Definition 3 (Quantitative question types)

- **Problem-solving** — a conventional multiple-choice question: a problem is posed and you select the correct value or expression from five options.
- **Data Sufficiency** — you are given a question and two statements, and you must decide whether the statements provide **enough information** to answer — not what the answer is.

Problem-solving you already understand in form; the work there is **speed and trap-avoidance**, covered below. Data Sufficiency is genuinely new, and it defeats strong mathematicians more often than weak ones, precisely because they cannot stop themselves from solving.

2.2 The Data Sufficiency logic shift

Worked example — Why solving is the wrong move. Question: What is the value of the integer n ?

Statement (1): n is a prime number between 90 and 100.

Statement (2): n is odd.

A reflex mathematician starts hunting for n . Stop. The question is not “find n ” — it is “**can** n be pinned down?” Statement (1) alone: the only prime between 90 and 100 is 97, so $n = 97$ is forced — **sufficient**. Statement (2) alone: countless odd integers exist — **not sufficient**. You answer that (1) alone suffices and (2) alone does not, and you never needed to “use” the value 97 for anything. You spent perhaps fifteen seconds.

Definition 4 (The Data Sufficiency question) Every Data Sufficiency item asks the **same** meta-question: **is the answer determinable from the information given?** You evaluate three scenarios — each statement alone, then the two combined — and report which combination is enough. You almost never compute the final value.

The five answer choices are fixed and identical on every Data Sufficiency question, so memorise them once and never re-read them under the clock:

- (A) Statement (1) alone is sufficient, but (2) alone is not.
- (B) Statement (2) alone is sufficient, but (1) alone is not.
- (C) Both together are sufficient, but neither alone is.
- (D) Each statement alone is sufficient.
- (E) Even together they are not sufficient.

The efficient way to navigate these five is not to read them as a list but to walk a small decision tree, testing statement (1) first, then (2). This is the classic “AD / BCE” method:

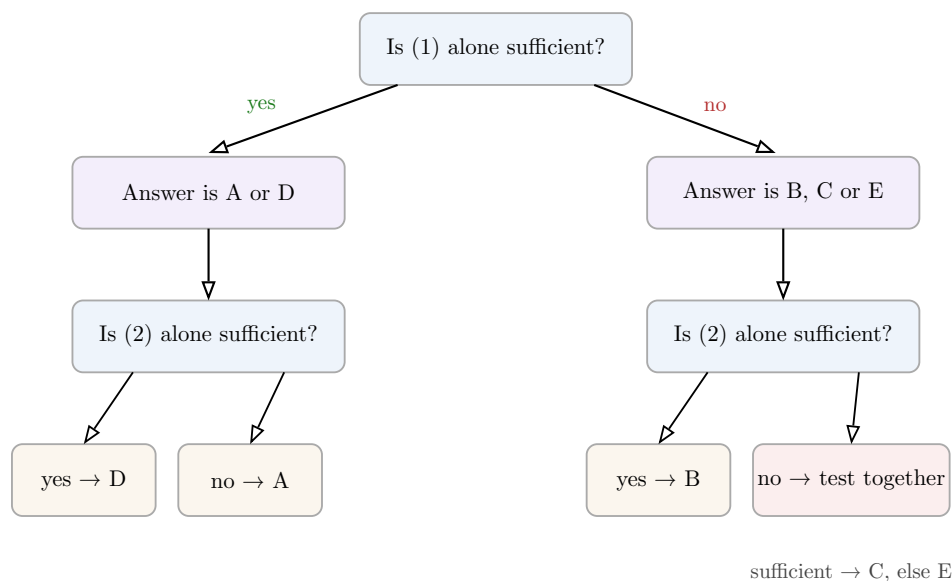


Figure 2: The Data Sufficiency decision tree (the “AD / BCE” method). Testing statement (1) first splits the five answers into two groups of fewer options, so each subsequent test is a simple yes/no. You evaluate the two statements **independently** before ever considering them together.

Common pitfall The deadliest Data Sufficiency trap is **carrying information between statements**. When you test statement (2) alone, you must forget everything statement (1) told you. Strong students unconsciously let (1)’s facts linger while judging (2), conclude that (2) “works,” and pick D when the answer is A. Treat the two statements as if read by two different people who never met.

Common pitfall A second trap: **assuming values are positive integers**. “Is $x > 0$?” with a statement like “ $x^2 = 9$ ” is **not** sufficient — x could be 3 or -3 . The GMAT routinely hides insufficiency in the cases you forget: negatives, zero, fractions. Before declaring a statement sufficient, ask “could a sneaky value break this?”

2.3 Time management and trap avoidance

Definition 5 (The pacing constraint) The Quantitative section gives you a fixed, generous-sounding total time spread across many questions, which works out to roughly **two minutes per question** on average. The clock is the real adversary: almost everyone could answer almost every question correctly with unlimited time. The score measures accuracy **per unit time**.

Three pacing rules follow, and they are worth more points than any single piece of mathematics:

1. **Spend your average, not your maximum, on each item.** A question you cannot crack in about two minutes is a question to mark, guess, and abandon. The minute you “win” by stubbornly finishing it is stolen from two later questions you would have answered correctly.

2. **Guard the opening.** Because the section is adaptive, early questions set the difficulty band you compete in. Read the first handful with extra care — a careless early slip is more expensive than a late one.
3. **Never leave blanks if you can help it.** An unanswered question typically costs more than a wrong one. When time is gone, guess and move on.

Worked example — Plug in the answers instead of solving. **Question:** For which value of x is $(x - 2)(x + 5) = 18$?

(A) 1 (B) 3 (C) 4 (D) 6 (E) 7

The “mathematician’s” path expands to $x^2 + 3x - 28 = 0$, factors, and solves. The “test-taker’s” path tries (C): $(4 - 2)(4 + 5) = 2 \cdot 9 = 18$. ✓ Done in ten seconds. On a multiple-choice section, the answer options are **part of the problem** — back-solving and estimating are often faster than the honest method.

Quantitative, in one line: the mathematics is easy; the test is hard. Your edge comes from the Data Sufficiency logic shift, from pacing discipline, and from exploiting the multiple-choice format (back-solving, estimating) rather than solving everything from first principles.

3 Verbal section strategy

The Verbal section is not an English exam. It will not reward a wider vocabulary or more elegant prose; it rewards **recognising the reasoning patterns the test repeats**. There are only so many ways the GMAT can build a critical-reasoning question or a sentence-correction trap, and the trained eye sees the pattern before reading the options.

3.1 Three question types

Definition 6 (Verbal question types)

- **Reading comprehension** — questions on a supplied passage, testing whether you grasped its structure and claims, not whether you memorised its details.
- **Critical reasoning** — questions on the logic of a short argument: what would strengthen it, weaken it, or must be assumed for it to hold.
- **Sentence correction** — selecting the best-formed version of an underlined sentence from five options that differ in grammar and concision.

3.2 Reading comprehension: read for structure, not content

Worked example — Mapping a passage. A passage opens: “For decades, economists attributed the productivity slowdown to falling investment. Recent work, however, suggests a subtler cause...” Before reading further, a trained test-taker already knows the **shape**: an old view, a pivot (“however”), and a new view that the passage will defend. The questions will almost certainly probe the contrast — what the old view missed, what the new view claims. Reading for that **skeleton** — claim, pivot, support — lets you answer detail questions by knowing **where** to look, instead of holding the whole passage in your head.

The mistake to avoid is reading for **retention**. You are not being tested on recall; you can scroll back to the text. Read once for the argument’s architecture, then return to the passage to pin down each specific answer.

3.3 Critical reasoning: find the gap

Definition 7 (The anatomy of a GMAT argument) A critical-reasoning argument has three parts: stated **evidence**, a **conclusion** drawn from it, and — crucially — an unstated **assumption** bridging the two. Most questions live at that bridge: “weaken” attacks the assumption, “strengthen” shores it up, and “assumption” questions name it outright.

Worked example — Locating the assumption. Argument: “Our café’s revenue rose 20% after we introduced oat milk. Therefore oat milk drove the increase.”

The **evidence** is the correlation; the **conclusion** is causal. The hidden **assumption** is that nothing else changed — no new foot traffic, no price rise, no seasonal swing. To **weaken**: “A new office block opened next door that month.” To **strengthen**: “Sales of every other item were flat.” Notice you evaluate the options by how they hit the **assumption**, never by whether they sound plausible in isolation.

Common pitfall In critical reasoning the wrong answers are engineered to be **tempting**. The most common trap is the **out-of-scope** option — a true, sensible statement that simply does not bear on this argument’s gap. “Oat milk is healthier than dairy” may be true and relevant to **life**, but it neither strengthens nor weakens a claim about **revenue**. Always ask: does this option touch the specific bridge between this evidence and this conclusion?

3.4 Sentence correction: meaning and concision over “sounds right”

Definition 8 (What sentence correction tests) Five versions of a sentence differ in grammar, structure, and length. The best answer is the one that is grammatically correct, unambiguous in meaning, and **concise** — the GMAT consistently prefers the shorter, clearer construction when meaning is preserved.

Common pitfall Do not choose by ear. Constructions that “sound right” out loud — comfortable redundancies, conversational filler — are exactly the bait. Look instead for the GMAT’s recurring targets: subject–verb agreement across long interrupting clauses, faulty parallelism in lists, dangling modifiers, and ambiguous pronouns whose antecedent is unclear. Decide on a **rule**, not on a feeling.

Verbal, in one line: read comprehension for **structure**, critical reasoning for the **assumption-gap**, sentence correction for a grammatical **rule** and concision. In all three, the wrong answers are designed to feel right — decide by pattern, not by instinct.

4 Integrated Reasoning strategy

Integrated Reasoning is the section that most resembles the work you will actually do in a data-business career — and the one students most often under-prepare because it does not feed the headline Total Score. Treat that as an opportunity: a modest investment here is both a score gain and a rehearsal for professional data-interpretation tasks.

4.1 Four formats

Definition 9 (Integrated Reasoning formats)

- **Multi-source reasoning** — information split across several tabs of text, tables, or charts; you must synthesise across them to answer.
- **Graphics interpretation** — read a chart or graph and complete statements from drop-down options.
- **Table analysis** — a sortable table you interrogate to judge a set of true/false-style claims.
- **Two-part analysis** — a problem with two linked components answered together in a grid.

4.2 Strategy: practise the format, not the mathematics

The mathematics buried in Integrated Reasoning is no harder than the Quantitative section's — often easier. What makes the section hard is **format friction**: the time lost learning, mid-exam, how a sortable table behaves or how a multi-tab prompt is laid out. Eliminate that friction in advance.

Worked example — Sorting before reading. A table-analysis prompt shows 30 companies with revenue, headcount, and margin, and asks whether “the company with the highest margin also has above-median headcount.” The novice reads all 30 rows. The trained test-taker **sorts by margin** with one click, reads the top row's headcount, sorts by headcount to find the median, and answers in twenty seconds. The skill being tested is not arithmetic; it is **knowing the tool exists and reaching for it**.

Common pitfall Many Integrated Reasoning questions are **all-or-nothing**: a two-part or multi-statement item gives no credit unless every component is right. Do not rush the second half of a question after nailing the first — a single careless click wastes the whole item.

Integrated Reasoning, in one line: the math is easy, the **format** is the obstacle. Drill each of the four layouts until navigating them is automatic, so that on test day you spend your time reasoning, not figuring out the interface.

5 Analytical Writing Assessment

The AWA asks for one thing, and asks for it under a strict 30-minute clock: a written **critique of the reasoning** in a given argument. Note the word — critique, not opinion. You are not asked whether you agree with the argument's conclusion. You are asked to dissect **how well it is argued**, which is exactly the critical-reasoning skill from the Verbal section, now in essay form.

5.1 What the task is — and is not

Common pitfall The single most common AWA failure is **answering the wrong question**. The prompt is never “do you support raising the minimum wage?” It is “evaluate the reasoning of **this** argument about the minimum wage.” An essay that argues your own position, however eloquent, misses the task. Attack the **logic**, not the **conclusion**.

5.2 A reusable essay structure

Because the task is the same every time, you can walk in with a skeleton and fill it. Spend the first few minutes finding the argument's flaws, then write to a fixed plan:

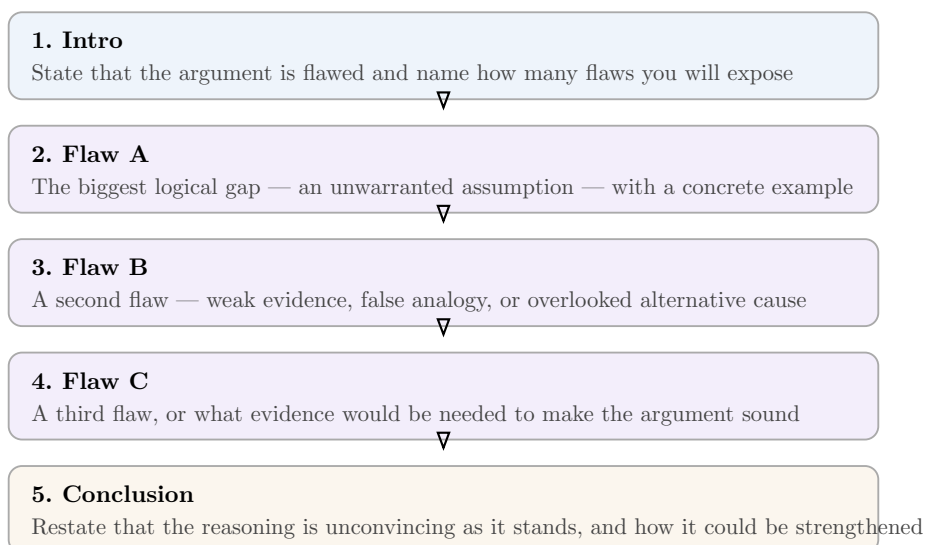


Figure 3: A reusable AWA skeleton. Because every prompt asks the same thing — critique the reasoning — you can pre-plan this five-part structure and spend your scarce minutes finding flaws, not inventing an essay shape.

5.3 Logical fallacies the GMAT tests

Definition 10 (The recurring AWA fallacies) The arguments the GMAT hands you are deliberately flawed, and the flaws repeat:

- **Causation from correlation** — “X rose after Y, so Y caused X.”
- **Unrepresentative sample** — a sweeping conclusion drawn from a narrow or biased survey.
- **False analogy** — assuming what worked in one setting transfers to a different one.
- **Overlooked alternative cause** — ignoring other explanations for the evidence.
- **Unsupported assumption** — a hidden premise the argument needs but never establishes.

Worked example — Turning a fallacy into a paragraph. Prompt argument: “Store A cut prices and sales rose; therefore Store B should cut prices to raise its sales.”

Your Flaw A paragraph: identify the **false analogy** — Store B may serve a different clientele, sit in a different location, or face different competition, so what worked for A need not work for B. One named fallacy, one or two concrete reasons it applies **here**. That is a complete, high-scoring paragraph; you need three of them.

5.4 Planning under time pressure

A 30-minute AWA budget: 5 minutes reading the argument and listing its flaws, 20 minutes writing to the fixed skeleton, 5 minutes proofreading. The graders reward **clear structure and identified flaws** over flourish — a plain, well-organised, correctly-aimed critique beats an eloquent essay that argues the wrong thing.

6 Timed practice and error analysis

Strategy you have only read is worthless on test day. The OP requires each student to complete **at least two timed full sections** with score analysis, and this is where the abstract advice above becomes a measured habit. The mechanism that turns practice into points is not the practice itself — it is the **error analysis** afterward.

Definition 11 (The error log) After every timed section, record each question you missed and classify **why**: a **content** gap (you did not know the fact), a **strategy** error (you solved when you should have estimated, or carried a Data Sufficiency statement), a **careless** slip (you knew it but misread), or a **pacing** loss (you ran out of time). The category, not the question, tells you what to fix.

Worked example — Reading your own log. Idriss reviews his first timed Quant section: of nine misses, six are “pacing — ran out of time on the last block” and only one is a genuine content gap. The log makes the diagnosis obvious: he does not need more mathematics revision; he needs to practise **abandoning** hard questions faster. His second timed section, with a strict per-question cap, gains him 40 points — entirely from fixing pacing, not knowledge.

Common pitfall Do not “review” a practice test by simply re-reading the correct solutions and nodding. That feels productive and teaches almost nothing. The value is in **classifying** each error so a pattern emerges across the whole section — three careless slips in algebra, or a recurring out-of-scope trap in critical reasoning. You fix categories, not individual questions.

7 Weakness diagnosis and a personalised study plan

The two timed sections plus the initial diagnostic give you a portrait of yourself as a test-taker. The OP asks you to turn that portrait into a **written, personalised plan** for continued preparation beyond these 12 hours — because the course is an ignition, not the whole engine.

Definition 12 (What the study plan must contain) A usable post-course plan names four things:

1. **Weakness areas** — the specific question types and error categories your logs expose, in priority order.
2. **Targeted resources** — official practice materials and drills matched to those weaknesses, not a generic “study more.”
3. **A timeline** — a week-by-week schedule with a planned test date, working **backward** from your S6 MSc application deadlines.
4. **A target score** — the realistic number from Chapter 1, with a fallback.

Worked example — From log to plan. Léa’s diagnostics show a strong Quant, a Verbal dragged down by sentence correction, and good pacing. Her plan writes itself: priority is sentence correction; resource is a focused grammar-rules drill set plus 100 official sentence-correction questions; timeline is six weeks of two sessions per week, sitting the real test eight weeks before her earliest deadline; target 700, fallback 680. Specific, dated, and aimed at the **one** thing holding her Total down.

8 Admission strategy beyond the GMAT

A score is necessary, not sufficient. The final competence this course builds is **positioning**: placing your GMAT inside a coherent application that argues for you. This is where your particular background — an Albert School Bachelor in Data & Business — becomes an asset to be framed rather than a fact to be listed.

8.1 School selection

Definition 13 (Building a balanced target list) Select target programmes the way you would diversify any portfolio: a few **reach** programmes (your score sits at or below their range), a core of **match** programmes (your score sits comfortably in their upper half), and one or two **safety** programmes (your score clears their range). A list of only reaches is a gamble; a list of only safeties wastes your record.

8.2 How programmes weigh the dossier

Worked example — The same file, two committees. Consider one applicant — 700 GMAT, solid GPA, a strong data-internship, average essays — sent to two programmes. Programme X is score-driven and quantitative; it reads the 700 and the internship first, and the average essays barely register. Programme Y is fit-and-story-driven; it reads the essays first and finds them thin, and the 700 does not rescue the file. **Same dossier, opposite outcomes.** The lesson: learn how **each** target programme weighs score versus academic record versus experience versus recommendations versus essays, and put your effort where that particular committee actually looks.

8.3 Positioning the Albert School background

Definition 14 (Framing the Albert profile) An Albert School Bachelor is not a generic business degree, and you should never let a committee read it as one. Its distinctive elements are assets when named explicitly:

- **Data & Business (BDD)** — quantitative and data fluency fused with business education, exactly the hybrid top MSc programmes increasingly seek.
- **Multi-campus** — international mobility and adaptability across learning environments.
- **Data-business formation** — readiness for the data-driven roles that modern employers, and therefore selective programmes, target.

Common pitfall The mistake is to assume the committee already knows what Albert School is. Many will not. State the profile's strengths in plain terms — “a quantitative data-and-business Bachelor with international, multi-campus training” — and tie each to what **this** programme values. An unframed unusual background reads as a risk; a framed one reads as a differentiator.

Worked example — Positioning in one essay line. Weak: “I studied at Albert School.” (Assumes recognition; states nothing.)

Strong: “Albert School's data-and-business curriculum let me run a regression on a real customer dataset in my second year — the kind of quantitative-business hybrid your MSc in

Business Analytics is built around.” The strong version **names** the background, **evidences** it, and **connects** it to the specific programme.

8.4 Timeline alignment

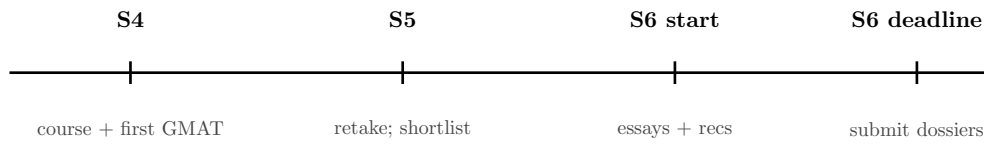


Figure 4: Why the course sits in S4. Taking the GMAT early leaves S5 to retake if the first score misses target, and frees S6 entirely for essays and recommendations — the parts of the dossier that cannot be rushed. A GMAT left until S6 collides with deadlines and forecloses a retake.

Admission strategy, in one line: the GMAT buys you a seat at the table; the **dossier** wins the offer. Build a balanced target list, learn how each programme weighs the file, frame the Albert data-and-business background explicitly rather than assuming it is known, and sequence everything backward from S6 deadlines so the GMAT is settled before the essays begin.